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VOL. 4 · ST. MARK

The Seat That Survived 2008: How the NNP Lost St. Mark

St. Mark stayed with the NNP when the party was routed in 2008, and again when it lost power in 2022. In 2026, with a new candidate on the ballot, its two-party share fell 14 points, faster than the country as a whole, and the NDC took the seat by 261 votes.

BY GREG HOSTEN ST. MARK, GRENADA

ST. MARK, GRENADA—St. Mark is Grenada's smallest parish and one of its most loyal constituencies. When the National Democratic Congress swept 11 of 15 seats in 2008, St. Mark stayed with the New National Party. When the NDC took government in 2022, St. Mark stayed again, giving Clarice Modeste-Curwen 1,470 votes to 995, almost 60 per cent of the two-party vote. It was one of only four NNP seats in 2008 and one of six in 2022.

"A loyal seat is loyal to someone. When she left the ballot, the vote fell faster than the national swing."
GREG HOSTEN

On 5th November that record came to an end. The NDC's Caris Degannes took 1,538 votes to 1,277 for the NNP's Mayanna Charles, a majority of 261. A seat that had withstood two NDC waves did not withstand the third.

A LOYAL SEAT, A NEW NAME

Ms. Modeste-Curwen, a former Minister of Health, Works and Tourism, had represented St. Mark through good years and bad, but she was not on the 2026 ballot. The NNP's candidate was Mayanna Charles, standing in a seat where the party's support had long rested heavily on its sitting member.

The NDC treated St. Mark as a prize from the outset. When Prime Minister Dickon Mitchell announced the election date in October, he named St. Mark in his own remarks as a place the party intended to win. A governing party does not single out a seat it expects to lose.

FASTER THAN THE NATIONAL SWING

The scale of the fall is the first thing to grasp. Between 2022 and 2026 the NNP's share of the two-party vote in St. Mark dropped from 59.6 per cent to 45.4 per cent, a fall of 14.3 points, against a national decline of 10.3 points. St. Mark did not merely follow the national tide; it ran four points ahead of it against the NNP.

Compare that with St. George North West, where Dr. Keith Mitchell handed over to a successor he had named in public ten months before polling day, and where the NNP's share fell by just 2.4 points. The two seats offer the clearest test in this series of what happens when a long-serving NNP member leaves the ballot: in one the vote held, while in the other it fell faster than the national swing.

NEW VOTERS, AND NEARLY ALL FOR THE NDC

The composition of the change matters. The NNP lost 193 votes, from 1,470 to 1,277, while the NDC gained 543, from 995 to 1,538. Even if every one of the NNP's lost voters had switched, at least 350 of the NDC's new votes came from people who had not voted for either main party in 2022.

The register in St. Mark grew by 510 names, 329 more ballots were cast, and turnout held almost exactly steady, at 67.3 per cent. The NDC, in other words, did not win St. Mark by persuading NNP voters; it won by reaching the new ones first.

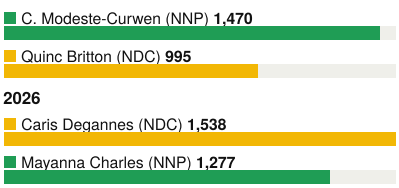
NOT A SINGLE STRONGHOLD LEFT

The polling-division returns show how evenly the NDC spread its gains. The NNP carried only 3 of the 13 divisions and tied a fourth: at the Victoria Pre-Primary School, one division split exactly 106 votes each.

The NNP's best ground was the St. Mark's Secondary School, where it took 51.3 per

2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



261 votes
NDC winning margin in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

261
NDC winning margin, ending an NNP hold that outlasted 2008 and 2022

−14.3 pts
Fall in the NNP's two-party share, faster than the national −10.3

3 of 13
Polling divisions won by the NNP, with one tied

131
Switchers the NNP needed to keep the seat

cent across three divisions and won one by 131 to 104, together with one of the two Duquesne divisions, which it won by 118 to 112. Its worst was Samaritan, where the NDC won both divisions by 210 votes to 97 between them; in one Samaritan division the NNP took barely more than a quarter of the two-party vote.

Victoria, the parish capital, was lost narrowly. The NDC took the two Victoria Child Development Centre divisions by 287 votes to 213, and the three Pre-Primary divisions by 335 to 316. The margins were small everywhere, and all of them ran the same way.

THE PARISH THAT CANNOT AFFORD TO BE IGNORED

St. Mark is small, with 4,200 registered voters this year, the fewest of any constituency in the country, and that is precisely why it matters. In a small seat a few hundred voters decide everything, and a party that is present every week can hold it against the national mood, as the NNP did in 2008.

The danger for the NNP is that small seats are easily taken for granted. A loyal member can mask the condition of the branch, which is tested only when the member leaves. In 2026 St. Mark was tested, and the result suggests that the party organisation beneath had not been maintained to the standard of the member's personal standing.

ONE HUNDRED AND THIRTY-ONE VOTERS

The arithmetic of a comeback is modest. To have held the seat, the NNP needed 131 voters to switch sides, or 262 more of its own supporters to turn out, the latter about one in five of the 1,373 registered voters who did not vote.

Few seats the NNP lost in 2026 can be recovered with so few votes; only St. Andrew South East, where the party needs 82 switchers, is closer. St. Mark should therefore stand near the top of any NNP target list for 2030/31.

WHAT CAN BE DONE: A FOUR-YEAR PLAN FOR ST. MARK

The NDC won St. Mark with new voters and an even spread of small gains. The NNP can win it back the same way, but only if it starts early.

Year one, 2027: name the candidate early and commit to that person for the next election, so that St. Mark's voters have four years, not four months, to come to know them. Reopen a permanent office in Victoria, and build a household list for each of the 13 polling divisions, beginning with the tied Victoria division and the two Duquesne divisions.

Year two, 2028: run a listening programme across the parish's principal communities: fishers and vendors in Victoria, farmers on the hillsides, young people and returning nationals. Publish what they say and build a short local programme from it. Register new voters every month, since the register grew by 510 in four years and the NDC found most of them.

Year three, 2029: recruit a captain for each of the 13 divisions, with a quarterly target for household contacts. Put particular effort into Samaritan, where the NNP took under a third of the vote, because a seat this small cannot be won while one community is written off.

Year four, 2030: campaign on numbers within reach. Hold St. Mark's Secondary School and Duquesne, win back the Victoria divisions lost by a handful of votes each, and narrow the gap in Samaritan. The target is 131 switchers or 262 new supporters.

THE LESSON FOR EVERY NNP SEAT

A loyal seat is loyal to someone. In St. Mark the NNP's strength rested on a sitting member who had held the seat through two NDC waves, and when she left the ballot the party's share fell faster than the national swing.

The method that worked in St. George North West was an early, public handover and a successor with time to become known; St. Mark shows the cost of its absence. Every NNP seat with a long-serving member, now or in future, should plan its succession years in advance.

THE ARITHMETIC OF ST. MARK

Measure	2022	2026	Change
NNP votes	1,470	1,277	−193
NDC votes	995	1,538	+543
NNP share of two-party vote	59.6%	45.4%	−14.3 pts
NNP two-party share nationally	48.0%	37.7%	−10.3 pts
Winning margin	NNP +475	NDC +261	736-vote swing
Registered voters	3,690	4,200	+510
Turnout	67.7%	67.3%	−0.4 pts
Registered voters who did not vote	1,192	1,373	+181
NNP votes as a share of all registered voters	39.8%	30.4%	−9.4 pts
Polling divisions won by the NNP	3 of 13 (1 tied)		
Switchers the NNP needed to win		131	

Two-party figures exclude minor candidates (2022: GULP 18). 2026 figures are provisional results from the Parliamentary Elections Office, all 13 polling divisions verified.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. Plan the succession: a loyal seat is loyal to its member, not automatically to the party.
2. Name new candidates early and in public, as in St. George North West.
3. Watch the register: it grew by 510, and the NDC found most of the new voters.
4. Fight for every division: the NDC won with small gains spread everywhere.
5. Do not write off Samaritan: in a seat this small, every community counts.
6. Reopen a permanent office in Victoria, the parish capital.
7. Captain all 13 divisions, starting with the tied Victoria division.
8. Target 131 switchers: one of the smallest gaps of any lost seat.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; polling divisions read 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 and 2008 general elections; Clarice Modeste-Curwen); Jamaica Gleaner / CMC (election date announcement, 5 Oct 2026); NOW Grenada (2026 results, 6 Nov 2026). Analytics computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 4 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.